Mary Oliver: a Beloved American Poet

Mary Oliver (1935–2019) was an American poet and one of the best-loved and best-selling poets of her era. Her poems are known for close, reverent attention to the natural world (birds, ponds, grasshoppers, woods, the shoreline) and for clear, accessible language that often moves from careful observation to a spiritual or moral question about how to live.

She was born in Maple Heights, Ohio, outside Cleveland. She later described her childhood as difficult and said the woods near her home were her refuge, where she walked and wrote from a young age. At 17 she visited Steepletop, the former home of poet Edna St. Vincent Millay in upstate New York, and ended up living there for several years, helping Millay's sister organize the poet's papers. She attended Ohio State and Vassar but did not earn a degree. For more than 40 years she lived in Provincetown, on Cape Cod, with her partner, the photographer Molly Malone Cook, who died in 2005. Its dunes, ponds, and marshes became the landscape of much of her work. She spent her final years in Florida and died in 2019.

Critics sometimes dismissed her as too simple or sentimental, but she won the field's highest honors and drew an enormous popular readership.

Major works

Poetry

- *No Voyage and Other Poems* (1963), her debut
- *Twelve Moons* (1979)
- *American Primitive* (1983), which won the **Pulitzer Prize for Poetry** (1984)
- *Dream Work* (1986), which includes "Wild Geese," one of her most famous poems
- *House of Light* (1990), which includes "The Summer Day," whose closing question about what you plan to do with your life is her most quoted line
- *New and Selected Poems* (1992), which won the **National Book Award**
- *White Pine* (1994) and *West Wind* (1997)
- *Why I Wake Early* (2004)
- *Thirst* (2006), written in grief after Cook's death, and her most openly religious book
- *Red Bird* (2008), *Swan* (2010), *A Thousand Mornings* (2012)
- *Dog Songs* (2013) and *Blue Horses* (2014)
- *Felicity* (2015)
- *Devotions* (2017), a selection she made herself covering her whole career

Prose

- *A Poetry Handbook* (1994) and *Rules for the Dance* (1998), both widely used guides to craft

- *Blue Pastures* (1995) and *Long Life* (2004), essay collections
- *Upstream* (2016), essays on nature, writing, and the writers who shaped her

Influences

Transcendentalism: a major influence.

- **Ralph Waldo Emerson.** She wrote the introduction to a Modern Library edition of Emerson's essays and writes about him admiringly in *Upstream*. She shared his belief that nature is a source of spiritual truth, his trust in individual perception over received authority, and his sense that the divine can be met directly in the world.
- **Henry David Thoreau.** Her life and work echo Thoreau closely: daily walks, deliberate attention to small creatures and places, simplicity, and solitude in nature as a path to insight. Like Thoreau at Walden, she returned to the same local ponds and woods for decades. She also lived on Cape Cod, a place Thoreau wrote about.
- **Walt Whitman.** She called Whitman a formative companion from her youth. His expansive sense of the self joined to all living things, his celebration of the body and the ordinary, and his free verse shaped her voice.

Other influences:

- **Edna St. Vincent Millay**, her early model, through her years at Steepletop
- **The English Romantics**, especially **Wordsworth**, along with Keats and Shelley, for the idea of nature as a moral and spiritual teacher
- **Edgar Allan Poe**, about whom she wrote with surprising affection
- **Rumi** and other mystical poets, for their ecstatic, devotional tone
- **Christian tradition**, which became more explicit in her later books, where prayer and praise appear directly

Where she differs from the Transcendentalists.

Emerson often moved quickly from nature to abstract ideas, treating the natural world mainly as a symbol of the spirit. Oliver stays much longer with the actual creature or place: the specific heron, the specific mushroom, even death and predation in the woods. Her spirituality comes out of concrete, physical attention rather than philosophical system-building. She is less a theorist than a practitioner, which in that respect puts her closer to Thoreau than to Emerson. Many critics see her as one of the clearest modern heirs of the Transcendentalist tradition.